



# Meaningful Credentials: What are Students Earning upon Graduation?

Clare Papay and Cate Weir

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 **ThinkCollege**  
**NATIONAL COORDINATING CENTER**

# This session

- Why credentials are important
- What we know about credentials currently offered by TPSIDs
- How to develop a meaningful credential



The TPSID National Coordinating Center at Think College is a project of the Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston.

The Center is funded by the Office of Postsecondary Education Grant #P407B100002.



# What is a credential?

- A credential is a verification of qualification or competency issued to a student by an accredited institution of higher education (IHE) – typically a diploma, certificate, or degree.
- Students earn the credential by following and completing a prescribed course of study

*Shanley, J., Weir, C., Grigal, M. (2014). Credential Action Planning Tool for Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities. Boston, MA, Think College, University of Massachusetts Boston*



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# Why are the credentials students with ID earn important?



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# Higher Education Credentials Vocabulary

ARE THESE TERMS FAMILIAR?

Postsecondary award, diploma, or certificate

Degree

Micro-credential

IHE-approved

Industry-recognized



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# Options for Credentials

- Program creates a new credential that only their students earn.
  - May be aligned with an industry-recognized credential
  - Certificate of completion of a program of study
  - May or may not have official IHE approval
- Program creates a new credential that all students can earn
  - Is approved by the IHE
- Offer access to an existing credential already approved by and awarded by the IHE



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# Credentials offered by TPSIDs 2017-2018

**98%** of programs offer a credential to students

Either

- a TPSID-developed credential (42 programs) or
- access to an existing credential not developed by the TPSID (3 programs)

**42** sites offer **60** total credentials  
8 sites offer more than 1 TPSID-developed  
credential

**All** credentials are postsecondary  
awards/certificates

**37** credentials (62%) are approved by IHE governance

**12** (20%) can be earned by non-TPSID students

**12** (20%) are reported to be aligned with an industry-recognized credential

*Examples:*

*National Retail Foundation*

*ServSafe Certification*

*Infant and Toddler CPR*

*Bloodborne Pathogens*

*Certified Dietary Aide*

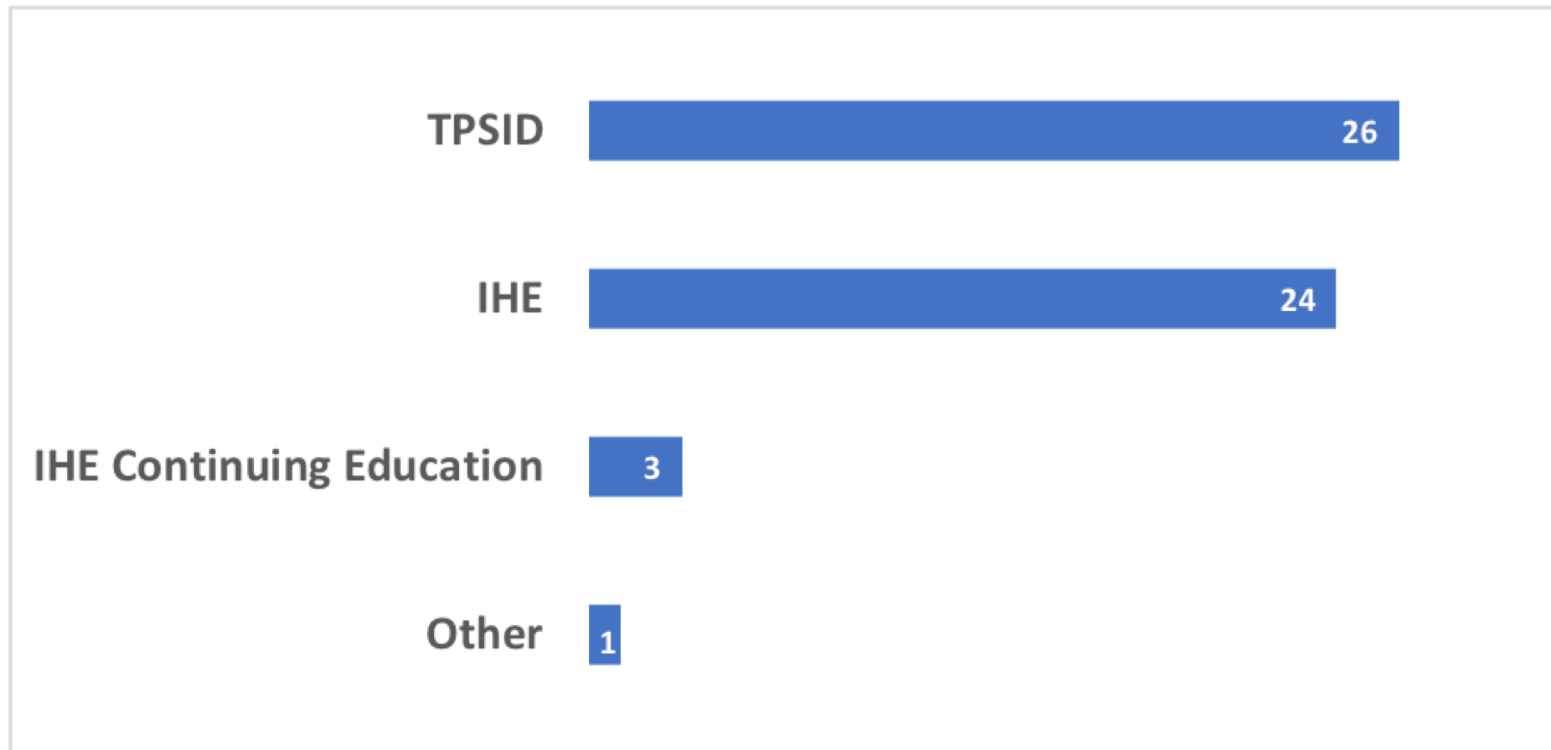
*Certified Logistics Associate*

*Child Development Associate*

*OSHA 10*

*Early Childhood Aide Certificate*

## Awarded by:



# Length of credential ranges from 1 to 4 years

- Most popular length is 2 years, followed by 4 years

## Credentials are measured in number of:

- Credits
- Semester hours
- Clock hours, or
- Courses

## Of credentials that measure in # credits, the range is:

- 18-56 credits for a 2-year program
- 45-75 credits for a 4-year program



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# Requirements include

## Inclusive coursework

- Required courses
- Elective courses
- Coursework is the main focus of the requirements

Internship or work experience

Portfolio, capstone, or other culminating project

Specialized coursework (few programs)

## Other

- Social engagement
- Independent living



# 243 Graduates

**235**

earned a  
TPSID  
credential



**8**

earned a degree or  
certificate available to all  
students

2015-2017

# Integrated Studies Certificate

- 27 hours 2-year/45 hours 4-year (General education hours additional)
- Core Program (18 credits)
  - identified as developing the student's primary transitional career & life goals.
  - Each core program is based on a match between the student's goals / interests and minors or modified majors offered to other students.
- Recommended general education electives
- Internships
  - 2 on campus, 1 off campus
- Capstone course (3 credits)



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# Certificate of Career and Community Studies

- 75 credits (4 years)
- University coursework (15 credits)
  - Graded or audited
  - Most students complete one year of Freshman Inquiry (5 for-a-grade or audited credits per term, 15 credits total) in Year One.
- Elective coursework (36 credits)
  - Graded or audited
  - Can include additional university coursework or internship/practicum
- ED402: CCS Independent study (24 credits)
  - Learning activities towards post-graduation goals
  - Individual College and Career Plan (ICCP) developed
- E-Portfolio



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# Business Office Assistant Certificate

- 18 credit hours (2 years)
- A subset of courses offered by the existing Business Technology degree program
- Listed along with all other Business Department degree/certificate offerings
- Graduates with this certificate are prepared to perform a variety of duties in any office clerical occupation that requires knowledge of office systems and procedures.
- Along with taking 6 college classes, the participants participate in human resource development workshops, social community integration, job shadowing and internships.



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# Industry Badges



- National Retail Association Badge Industry developed curriculum
  - Available in online modules for individualized instruction

[https://nrf.com/career-center/riseup/credentials#customer\\_service](https://nrf.com/career-center/riseup/credentials#customer_service)



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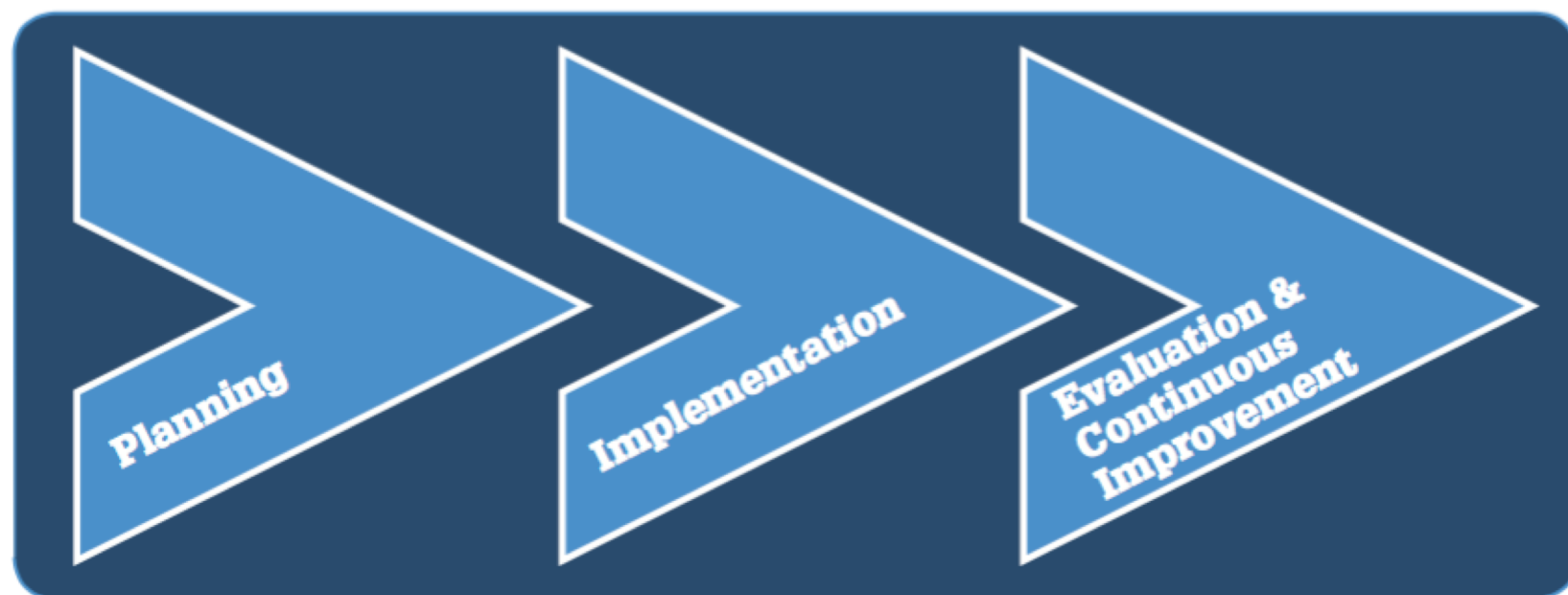
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# Credential Action Planning Tool for Postsecondary Education Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities

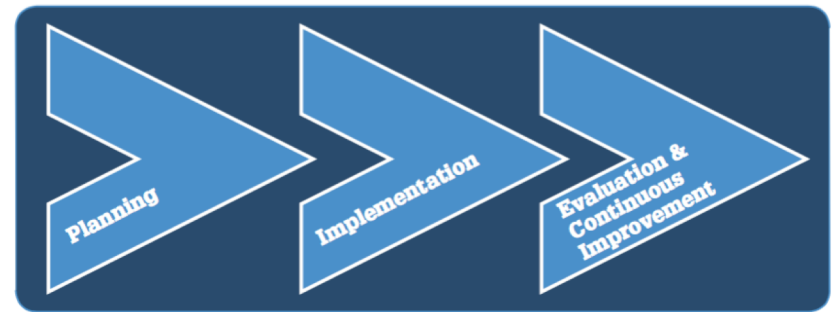


*By Judy Shanley, Cate Weir and Meg Grigal*



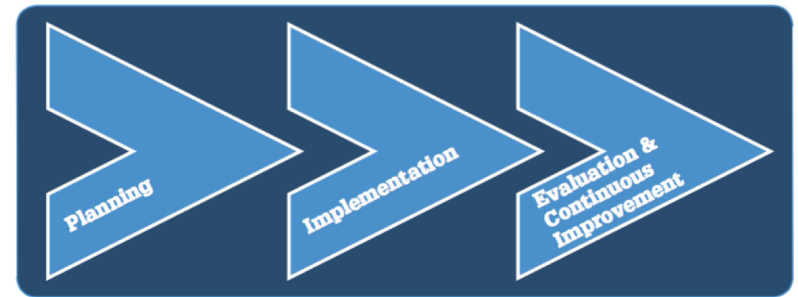


# Planning



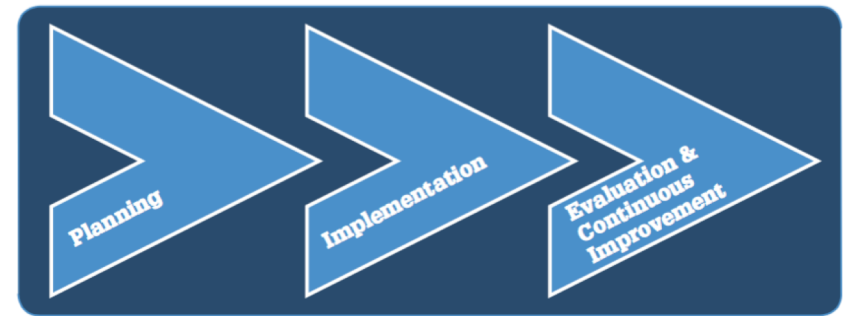
- **Convene a team** to develop the credential
- Formalize the **course of study** upon which the credential will be based
- Identify a **credential title** – will it mean anything to employers/students?
- Learn what other postsecondary programs for students with ID are doing to create a credential
- Review guidance for credential development provided by the Higher Education Act

# Obtaining IHE approval



- Understand your institutional policies and procedures related to establishing a credential
- Determine if the IHE has an **existing credential** that can be adopted or modified to serve as the credential for students in your program
- Speak with staff involved with institutional accreditation to determine how the credential you are developing may relate to program and/or institutional accreditation policies and procedures
- Design the credential to meet CTP requirements

# Implementation and Evaluation



- Determine and create marketing and informational communications about the credential
- Establish and implement an evaluation plan



# Resources

- [Non-Degree Credentials of Value](#): A PPT and webinar recording that discusses a variety of non-degree options for credentials currently in use in higher education
- [Creative Approaches to Meaningful Credentials](#) – April 2017 webinar presented by Barbara Bookman, Martha Mock, and Carrie Shockley
- [Credential Action Planning Tool](#)
- [Insight Brief on Credential Development](#)
- [Article on the micro-credentials movement in higher education](#)



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